



Accelerate those downloads!

The tricks necessary to free you from download blues...

There is no such thing as a free lunch, or too much bandwidth. Be it a cable connection, or dial-up, we all know the kinds of obstacles we face when downloading files from the Net—frequent disconnections, poor connection speeds and impossible file sizes are the bane of every surfer. But don't despair—there's hope, with a few tweaks and some good software.

Mirror, mirror on the Net

Tackle it head on: when you're downloading a file, you need to know the factors involved. First off, the location you download it from is important. If the file is not commonly found, you have no choice but to download it from the link you found it at; but if it is commonly available, you could find alternate servers. These are called mirrors. Always try to download a file from a mirror close to your geographical location. That is, if you have a Web site with a link in the UK and a mirror hosting the same file in China, download the file from the mirror.

Second, look at the pings and hops to the server and act accordingly (See box 'Ping Pong!'). But this should not be taken as a rule—a mirror with no traffic can give you better speeds, even if it is relatively far and takes more hops.

Nowadays, many servers offer queuing options to allow everyone a fair share of the bandwidth. It may be well worth the wait if the Web site offers good bandwidth. A queue server could have a high waiting time, and yet be able to allow high speeds. Try to find a server that is not clogged by other users. Then, identify its location and determine its peak hours, so that you can avoid them. Also, try to download from a site that supports download resuming.

Download managers

If you don't want to worry about pings, hops and mirrors, the best solution is a download manager. This typically monitors for download triggers, and proceeds with the transfer. The best download managers automatically ping mirrors, and decide which location is the best for downloading from.

Also, download managers provide the useful feature of resuming downloads. If you have a quirky connection (and who doesn't?), the resume feature is crucial. Basically, the resume feature is a series of checkpoints that the manager maintains. If the connection fails, the manager will resume the download from the last checkpoint. Most servers today support this.

Download managers also improve the speed of transfer using various techniques such as segmentation, best site selection and mirror search. Though most of these features are application dependent, all download managers have common functions that you need to bring some life to a slow connection.

There are many download managers available on the Internet. Here are a few that can help get your job done.

Mass Downloader 2.5 (www.metaproducts.com) follows a minimalist interface to guide you through your downloads. The program monitors Web addresses by mouse-clicks in the browser, and by clipboard entries. The triggering is quite accurate, and Mass Downloader also follows redirected links. This ensures that you will not download HTML pages instead of the actual file. Also, to download files, you can drag and drop links onto the download basket. The program automatically follows the link and proceeds to download the file. You can also schedule downloads to begin at a particular time.

Mass Downloader has another interesting feature that is quite useful while downloading archives. It allows you to view the contents of the

